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NASA to hold a live webcast of the New Horizons probe finally reaching the ex-planet pluto after about 9 years of journey. Read more: <http://dgit.in/plutoprobe>



Videocon's smart quotient

One of India's oldest consumer technology and appliances brand, Videocon is on the cusp of launching a variety of smart gadgets into the market. Mr. Akshay Dhoot, Head of Technology and Innovation, Videocon, spoke to us about all this and more. Excerpts from our interview:

◀ Akshay Dhoot, Head of Technology and Innovation, Videocon

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Q Do you think the Indian market is really ready for smart appliances?

Akshay Dhoot: When we made our Wi-Fi air conditioner, specifically, that was the result of a consumer research not because we wanted to do some new product, just like that. We realized that ACs consume a lot of power and it was the most, the heaviest power consuming appliance in any household. So one overwhelming feedback was a lot of people keep forgetting to switch off their AC or how they manage it. So the Wi-Fi AC was a result of this particular research and hence we also saw very good traction on it. We have sold some 10,000 pieces of this particular model of Wi-Fi AC. I know 10,000 is not a big number, but it's significant for this kind of category.

Q What sort of R&D has gone into the Wi-Fi AC?

Akshay: As far as R&D is concerned, we basically took a current standard PCB (printed circuit board), components and everything, studied what all we can do, what all info can be picked up from the AC and what all info can be thrown back into it. What we can pick up is errors and service issues that come up, and we can directly send the serviceman to the

customers. In terms of usability we can put in things like change the temperature and other basic things in the AC. All in all we had to add a complete Wi-Fi circuit to it. Also instead of an infrared remote, we added another module to bypass it.

Q Do you guys do remote diagnostics, maintenance, etc, for appliances?

Akshay: We have incorporated this feature, but not in all models. We have certain models which do remote diagnostics. But first to identify errors and recognize them uniquely, you need to have connectivity to all part of AC. We are working on integrating this technology now, and there's definitely as a product in the future, we will have a much more integrated AC in which we can get complete diagnostics of the each and every component of the AC.

Q Lastly, what are your thoughts on Internet of Things?

Akshay: Right now what's happened is a lot of people in India and worldwide, everyone's switched to smartphones, and they have become parts of the body. So the best feature of smartphone is its connectivity, it offers various ways of connecting. So what I am coming to is that smartphones are now complementing all other consumer electronics, appliances and all. If legacy devices can talk to smartphone, and the same can be used to

communicate with these devices, stream movie or control an AC, etc. It boils down to how people think, how they can use their smartphone to make their devices intelligent and smart. Basically, what we need are intelligent products, which actually understand context – like Google Now, which scans email for flight ticket bookings, different addresses and times of appointments, and automatically gives you relevant cards, at the right time. More such smart services are coming and a lot of them have come out and future is about these intelligent devices. Smart is already there, and as far as the next big thing it's about intelligent devices.

Q Don't u feel that this throw up very serious security threats?

Akshay: See I mean, there are always risks with new technology, always new challenges, for that we will work on the systems. When we really thought about getting these features out, when we got some features out in the AC or TV, we made sure that no customer info goes out, etc. Take Android phones, for e.g., the entire software is controlled by Google, and these phones are connected to Internet. If some software gets mishandled, anyone can activate a phone's mic, camera, even GPS location. Despite this potentially catastrophic scenario, people don't stop using these devices now, do they? **Q**